AEP FROM ZERO • PART 1 • KNOW YOUR CUSTOMER (AEP)

EPISODE 08

AEP Real-Time Customer Profile & Merge Policy

What is the Real-Time Customer Profile in Adobe Experience Platform, and how does an AEP merge policy decide which value wins? In this AEP tutorial, Bloom proves its customer schema feeds Profile with the union schema, then compares timestamp-ordered and dataset precedence merge policies on one real conflict: Dallas or Austin. You will learn how duplicate CRM rows on one email become one profile, what Default Timebased and ID stitching (None or Private graph) do, and why a merge policy is

Previously: one Priya, two cities

- Last time: five fragments, one identity graph
- The app sign-in was the linking event
- CRM, 2023: Dallas. App, 2026: Austin
- Today: the profile and the merge policy
- Goal: decide who owns the truth

KEY IDEA

Priya is one identity graph now, but two of her records disagree about where she lives. Today: the profile, and who decides what it shows.

What is the Real-Time Customer Profile?

- One merged, current view of a person
- Union of every attribute and event
- Built only from Profile-enabled datasets
- Priya: Email, BloomID and ECID, one person
- Journeys and audiences read it, not datasets

KEY IDEA

The Real-Time Customer Profile is one merged, current view of a person: the union of every attribute and event, read by journeys and audiences.

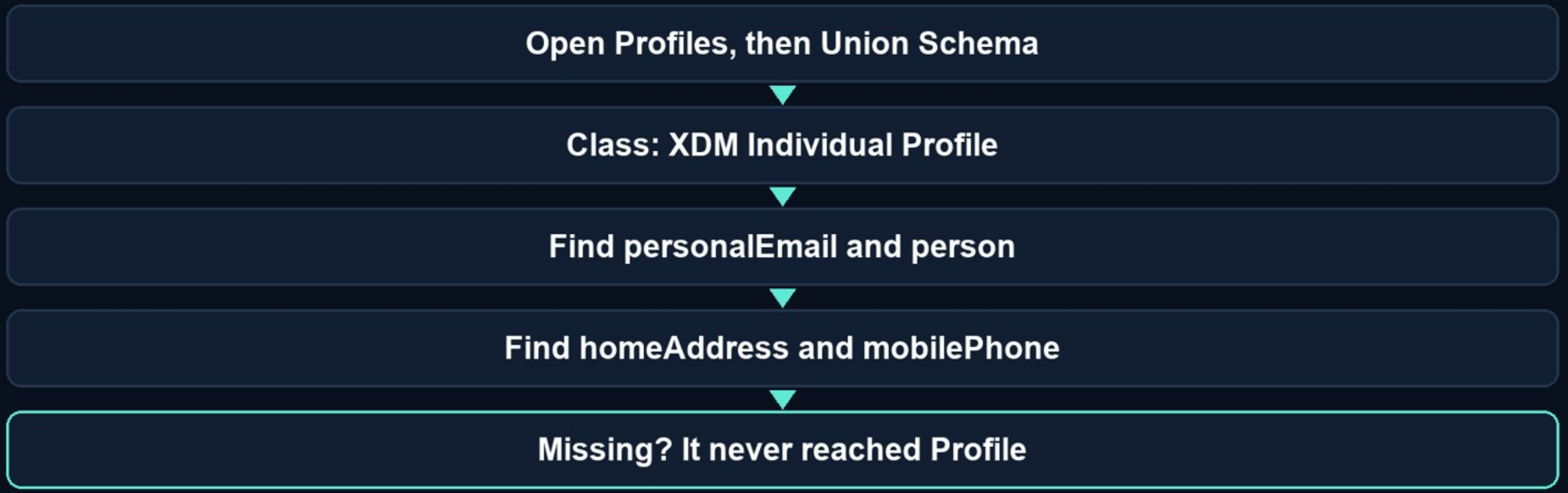
Profile truth versus dataset truth

Question	Data lake	Profile store
Holds	Every row, as it arrived	One current person
Speed	Thorough, not fast	Answers in milliseconds
Priya's city	A Dallas row, an Austin row	One city, by merge policy
Read by	History questions	Journeys and audiences

KEY IDEA

The lake keeps every row as it arrived; the profile shows one merged answer. Journeys need the answer, not the archive.

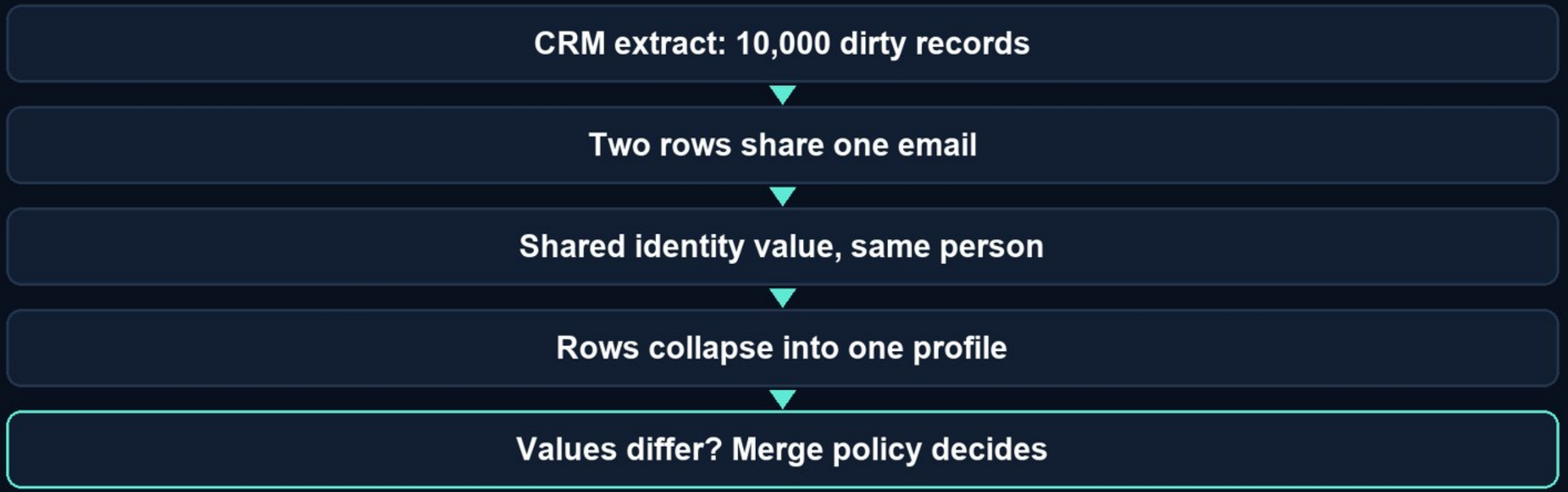
Prove the plumbing: the union schema



KEY IDEA

The union schema merges every Profile-enabled schema of one class. Seeing your schema's objects there is the cheapest proof it feeds Profile.

Duplicate rows, one customer



KEY IDEA

Rows that share one email are one person, so duplicate CRM rows collapse into one profile. Where they disagree, the merge policy picks the value.

What is a merge policy?

- The rule for which value wins a conflict
- CRM, 2023: Dallas. App, 2026: Austin
- Timestamp-ordered: newest value wins
- Dataset precedence: ranked source wins
- Also sets ID stitching: None or Private graph

KEY IDEA

A merge policy is the rule that decides which value wins when two sources disagree about the same person. It is a business decision.

Timestamp-ordered or dataset precedence?

Policy	Priya's city	Use when
Timestamp-ordered	Austin: newest wins	The newest value is truest
Dataset precedence	Dallas: CRM ranked first	One system is the authority

Same data, two answers

KEY IDEA

Timestamp-ordered lets the newest value win. Dataset precedence lets a ranked source win. Same data, two answers: choose by what the attribute means.

Inside Merge Policies: Default Timebased

Profiles, then Merge Policies

▼

Default Timebased, default: Yes

▼

1: Configure

▼

2: Select Profile datasets

▼

3: Select ExperienceEvent datasets

▼

4: Review. Leave without saving

KEY IDEA

Every sandbox ships Default Timebased, the policy used when nobody names one. Its editor is a four-step wizard. Read it; do not edit it.

ID stitching: None or Private graph

Setting on Configure	What it decides
ID stitching: None	Profile from a single identity
ID stitching: Private graph	Profile across the whole identity graph
Default merge policy	Used when nobody names a policy
Active-On-Edge Merge Policy	Same policy for edge decisions

KEY IDEA

ID stitching decides whether a profile is assembled from a single identity or across the whole identity graph. For Priya, that decides everything.

A business decision with a named owner

- No technically correct answer, only business
- Newest wins: right for a delivery address
- Newest wins: wrong for a legal name
- Decision note: attribute, sources, policy
- Owner for home address: Anjali, in writing

KEY IDEA

No merge policy is technically correct. Newest-wins suits a delivery address and fails a legal name. A named business owner decides, in writing.

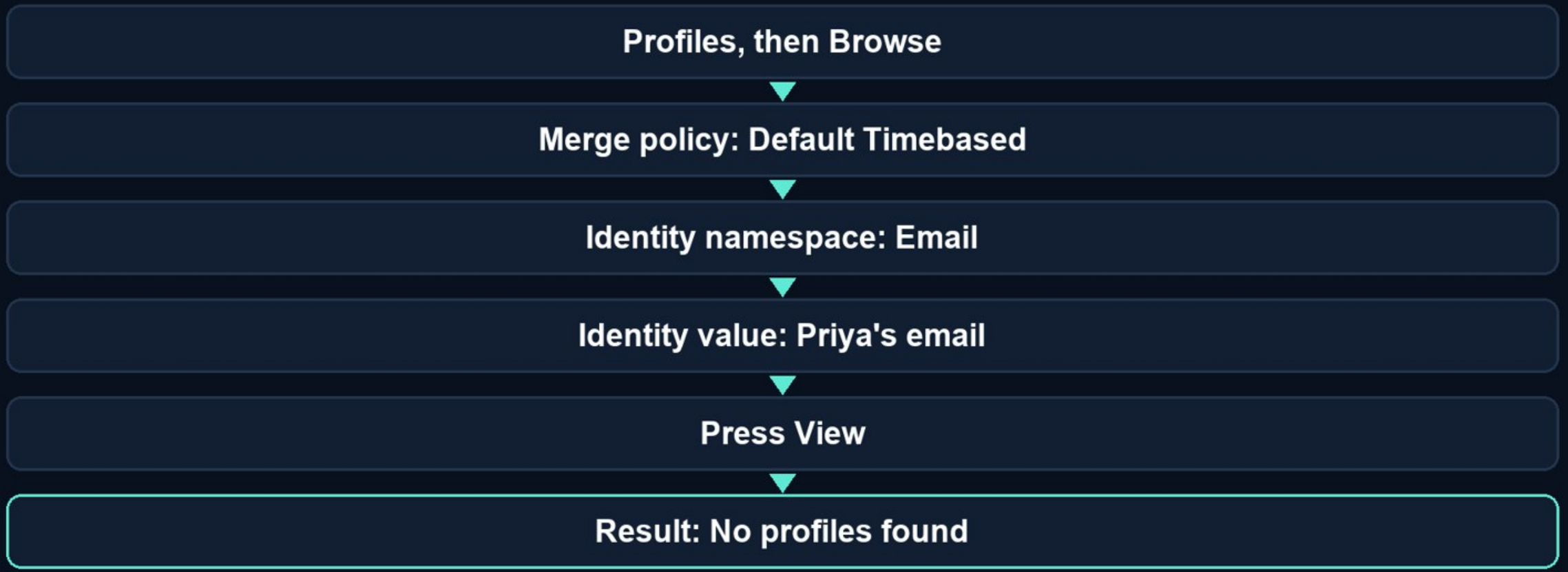
Profile hygiene: anonymous profiles, counts

- Pseudonymous profile: ECID only, not stitched
- Treat it as anonymous for privacy
- Do not let anonymous profiles pile up
- Watch the licence-relevant counts
- Data expiry settings exist: check the docs

KEY IDEA

Keep pseudonymous, ECID-only profiles from piling up, and watch the counts that matter for the licence. Check Adobe's docs on data expiry.

Looking Priya up: No profiles found



KEY IDEA

Profiles, Browse: choose a merge policy, a namespace and a value, then View. Kavya did everything right, and the screen said No profiles found.

Interview corner

- “The merge policy is a business decision,
- not a technical default.”
- Proof: same data, Dallas or Austin
- Close: written down, with a named owner

KEY IDEA

“The merge policy is a business decision, not a technical default.” Back it with Dallas, Austin and a named owner.

Recap, your question, and next time

- Profile: one current person, read by journeys
- Union schema: the cheapest proof of Profile
- Merge policy: newest or ranked source wins
- Every merge policy needs a named owner
- Next: green everywhere, yet no Priya

KEY IDEA

The profile is the current person; the union schema proves the plumbing; a merge policy is a business decision. Next: why is Priya missing?